



Guilt Is Not a Good Advisor

Why you always feel like you're falling short with your children, and what that guilt is actually stopping you from doing.

VIVIANNE DOS SANTOS

This ebook is a self-knowledge and understanding resource e compreensão. It does not replace therapeutic support. If you feel that your guilt is persistently paralysing you, if you experience symptoms of depression, intense anxiety, or if you are going through a crisis, please seek professional help. There is no shame in that. There is courage.

1. The thing you feel and never said

You know what I'm talking about.

That feeling that shows up when you lie down and the house is finally quiet. When the youngest has fallen asleep, when the dishes are done, when there is nothing left to do except be with yourself. And it shows up. The guilt.

It doesn't come with a warning. It doesn't come with a clear reason. It comes as a weight on your chest, an invisible list of everything you did wrong, everything you should have done better, everything another mother would have done differently.

You know exactly what it's like. But you've never told anyone.

Because who does? Who, in the middle of a conversation with other mothers, raises her hand and says: "I feel like I'm failing every day"? Who confesses, out loud, that there are nights she cries in the shower because she thinks she's ruining her own children?

Who admits that sometimes, when the kids finally fall asleep, the first thing she feels isn't relief, but a wave of regret for all the moments during the day when she wasn't who she wanted to be?

Who says, out loud, that sometimes she watches her children play and, instead of feeling joy, feels a pressure in her chest because she knows that in an hour she'll lose her patience again? Who confesses that the phrase "enjoy it, they grow up so fast" doesn't bring comfort, it brings guilt, because you know you're not enjoying it, you're surviving?

Nobody says it. And so you think you're the only one.

You're not.

I know because I feel it too. I have three children. Three whole people who depend on me in different ways, at different times, with needs I often can't meet all at once. And there are days when I look back and the only thing I see is what I didn't do, what I didn't say, what I couldn't give.

There are days when I'm helping one with homework and the other comes to ask for my attention, and I say "wait a moment," and that moment stretches, and when I finally look at him, he's already given up and walked away. And the guilt takes note. One more.

There are days when I reach the end of the afternoon so drained that the only thing I can do is put a screen in front of them to get thirty minutes of silence. And while they stare at the tablet, I stare at the ceiling and

the guilt asks me: "is this how you want them to remember their childhood?"

Guilt doesn't knock on the door. It's already inside when you wake up. It's the first thing you feel when your oldest looks at you with those eyes. It's the silent companion of every decision: "I should have stayed longer," "I shouldn't have yelled," "she needed me and I was on the phone."

It shows up when you sit in the car after dropping them off at school and mentally replay the morning. The yell you let out because nobody could find their shoes. The rush. His face when you said "hurry up, I've had enough." He didn't say anything. But his eyes said everything. And the guilt saved that image to show you at night, in the dark, when you can no longer defend yourself.

It shows up on Sunday, when you decide to stay on the couch instead of going to the park, and the voice tells you that one day they'll be adults and will remember the afternoons when their mother "didn't want to go." They won't remember that you were exhausted. They'll only remember that you didn't go.

It shows up when you see your daughter drawing alone at the kitchen table while you sort the laundry, and you think: "I should be sitting there with her, I should be asking her what she's drawing, I should be giving her attention." But the laundry doesn't wash itself. And guilt knows nothing about logistics. It only knows how to condemn.

It shows up when you're at work and the school calls because he has a fever, and you feel at the same time the fear that he's unwell and the shame of having to ask to leave early, and the double guilt: for not being with him, and for not being at work. There is no place you can be where guilt doesn't tell you that you should be somewhere else.

And the cruelest part is that guilt is always right. Not because you've failed. But because it always finds evidence. There is always something you could have done better. There is always a version of you that was more patient, more present, more calm. That version doesn't exist, but guilt swears it does.

And you believe it.

You believe it because the whole of society helps you believe it. Because the parenting books give you a list of things you shouldn't do and you recognize half of them. Because social media shows you mothers

who seem happy, organized, present, beautiful, with their children smiling in photographs that smell of lavender and perfection.

You believe it because the neighbor seems to have everything under control. Because your sister-in-law never yells. Because the mother of your child's classmate sends perfect homemade snacks and you send a packet of biscuits and a juice box, and the guilt whispers: "you can't even do this."

And you, who yelled yesterday because you couldn't take it anymore, look at those photographs and the guilt smiles.

"See? They can do it. You can't."

And the worst part isn't even the photographs. The worst part is the real conversation, face to face, with another mother. When she tells you, with a smile, that her son loves broccoli. That he's slept through the night since he was six months old. That she never yells. And you hear all of that and your first reaction isn't happiness for her. It's shame for yourself. Because your son doesn't eat broccoli, wakes up three times a night, and you yelled yesterday morning before eight.

And you don't say anything. You smile. You say "how wonderful." And you save the shame for later, when the guilt comes to keep you company.

This is not a flaw in you. This is a mechanism. And that's what we're going to talk about.

Not to remove your guilt with a pretty sentence. Not to tell you that "everything is fine" when you know there are things that need to change. But to show you what guilt really is, where it came from, and what it's stopping you from doing.

Because guilt is not making you a better mother. It's doing exactly the opposite.

And I know that, as you read this, a part of you is already saying: "but if I didn't feel guilt, maybe I wouldn't try as hard." That is guilt's great lie. That without it, you'd be worse. That without it, you wouldn't care. That it's the thing keeping you alert, attentive, dedicated.

It's not. What keeps you attentive is love. And love works much better without guilt on top of it.

2. Nobody talks about a mother's guilt

Everyone talks about the wounded child.

There are books, podcasts, courses, entire series dedicated to the inner child, to childhood trauma, to the wounds of those who grew up without what they needed. And it's important. It's real. Those wounds exist and need to be seen.

But there is one person in that story almost nobody talks about: the mother.

Not the mother as a cause. The mother as a person. The woman who carries, in silence, a guilt that no one taught her how to put down. The woman who hears "it's always the mother's fault" so many times that she starts to believe it's true, even when she did everything she could, even when she gave everything she had, even when what she had wasn't enough because nobody gave it to her first.

Open a social media feed, a popular psychology book, an article on child development. What do you find? "The mother did this wrong." "The mother didn't validate." "The mother was absent." "The mother was emotionally unavailable."

And all of that may be true. But it's an incomplete truth. Because that mother who "failed" is also someone. She also has a story. She also carries wounds. She also did the best she could with the resources she had, and often those resources were almost none.

The narrative is always the same: the child suffered. The mother failed. Period.

But that's not the whole story. The whole story includes the mother who was also a daughter. Who also had a mother. Who also grew up with rules she didn't choose, with silences she didn't ask for, with pain she inherited without knowing.

It includes the woman who had her first child in her early twenties and nobody asked if she was ready. It includes the woman who works eight, nine, ten hours a day and comes home with the remnants of herself to give to her children. It includes the woman who is alone, with no support network, no grandparents nearby, no one who says "rest, I'll stay with them."

It also includes the woman who has support but doesn't allow herself to use it. Because asking for help means admitting she can't handle it. And not handling it is, in the grammar of guilt, the final proof that you've failed.

It includes the woman who, when she finally sits down at night and someone asks her "how was your day?", doesn't know where to begin. Because the day had no beginning and no end. It was a continuous cycle of giving, deciding, solving, calming, cleaning, feeding, organizing, driving, and repeating. And none of that counts as "work." Nobody applauds. Nobody says thank you. And at the end of the day, the only thing left is the feeling that it wasn't enough.

The mother who raised you did what she knew. And you, who became a mother, do what you know. And what you know has limits. Not because you're weak. Because nobody knows everything. Because motherhood is not a skill you learn from a book. It's a crossing you make with your body, with your history, with your wounds, with love and with mistakes, all at the same time.

And the guilt shows up because you know, deep down, that there are things you're doing that you didn't want to do. There are moments when you hear yourself and don't recognize yourself. There are days when the mother who shows up is a version of you that scares you.

The voice that yells is yours but doesn't feel like yours. The impatience that explodes seems to come from a place you don't know. And then, when the calm returns, you look at what you did and think: "who was that person?"

It was you. A version of you that was at the breaking point. A version that isn't a defect, it's overload.

And you know what else nobody tells you? That most of the mothers you know have that same version hidden away. The mother who always seems calm has her limits too, she just reaches them in a different place, at a different time, away from your eyes. The difference between you and other mothers isn't that they don't explode. It's that you don't see it when they do.

But instead of looking at the why, guilt pushes you toward compensation. Instead of stopping and asking "where does this come from?", guilt tells you: do more, give more, be more.

And you do. And you're exhausted. And the guilt doesn't shrink. Because it wasn't doing that it needed. It was being seen.

In this ebook, I'm going to talk about the mother. The woman behind the mother. The guilt she carries and what that guilt hides from her.

Because it's time someone looked at you. And not just at what you've done.

3. Feeling guilt doesn't make you a bad mother

Read this slowly. If you need to, read it again.

Only those who love feel guilt.

A mother who doesn't love doesn't feel guilt. Doesn't lose sleep. Doesn't question herself. Doesn't cry in the shower. Doesn't open this ebook.

The fact that you feel guilt is not proof that you've failed. It's proof that you care. It's proof that, despite the exhaustion, despite the mistakes, despite the days when you yelled or when you weren't there, there is a part of you that wants to do better. That wants to give more than she received. That wants to protect those three (or two, or one, or five) human beings from all the pain in the world.

And that part is love. Pure, imperfect, tired, beautiful love.

If you stop and think, every worry you have is born from a place of love. You worry about his diet because you want him to be healthy. You worry about the time you spend away because you want him to feel safe. You worry about the yelling because you don't want him to associate love with fear. All of this is love. All of it.

But guilt is a terrible translator. It takes your love and translates it as failure. It takes your concern and translates it as incompetence. It takes your desire to be better and translates it as proof that you're not enough.

When you worry about what your child eats, guilt doesn't say "you care about his health." It says "you're not feeding him well." When you worry about the time you spend away from home, guilt doesn't say "you value being present." It says "you're abandoning him." When you worry about the impact of your reactions, guilt doesn't say "you're self-aware." It says "you're traumatizing him."

And you, who don't know the difference, believe the translation.

Let me tell you the difference.

Guilt says: "I failed." Love says: "I care."

Guilt says: "I should have done more." Love says: "I did what I could with what I had."

Guilt says: "I'm a bad mother." Love says: "I'm a mother who loves and who makes mistakes, like all mothers who love."

Guilt says: "my child will be scarred by this." Love says: "I can repair, I can apologize, I can try again tomorrow."

The difference is subtle. But it changes everything. Because when you listen to guilt, you freeze. When you listen to love, you act. And acting with love, even imperfect love, is exactly what your children need.

They don't need a perfect mother. They need a present mother. And present doesn't mean always available. Present means being truly there when you are there. It means looking at them and them knowing they are being seen. Not judged. Seen.

Do you know one of the greatest gifts you can give a child? Showing them that their mother is also human. That she also makes mistakes. That when she makes mistakes, she acknowledges them. That when she acknowledges them, she repairs them. That teaches a child more about life than any manufactured perfection.

A child who grows up with a mother who never makes mistakes (or who pretends she doesn't) learns that making mistakes is forbidden. A child who grows up with a mother who makes mistakes and repairs them learns that making mistakes is human. And that love doesn't disappear with the mistake.

Think about this: when your child falls and scrapes his knee, you don't love him less. You pick him up, clean the wound, put on a bandage, and say "it's going to be okay." He knows you're there. Not because you pre-

vented the fall. Because you showed up after.

You also fall. You also get scraped. And your children don't need a mother who never falls. They need a mother who gets back up. Who shows that getting up is possible. Who shows that wounds heal.

You can yell and be present. You can make mistakes and be present. You can not know what to do and be present. Presence doesn't require perfection. It requires truth.

And guilt, with all its intensity, pulls you away from the truth. It pushes you toward an idealized version of yourself that doesn't exist and never will. And while you chase that version, you miss the one who is here, right now, reading these words, trying.

You are trying. And that, in itself, is more than many mothers ever had.

4. What guilt makes you do

This is the most important chapter of this ebook. If you're only going to read one, let it be this one.

Guilt isn't just a feeling. It's a motor. It makes you act in ways you wouldn't choose if you weren't under its weight. And the most perverse part is that the behaviors guilt pushes you toward are exactly the ones that prevent you from being the mother you want to be.

Let me show you the most common ones. Read slowly. See if you recognize yourself.

You give in when you shouldn't

Your child throws a tantrum. You know you shouldn't give in. You know the boundary you set was fair, that he needs to hear a no, that giving in now will teach him that if he screams loud enough, he'll get what he wants.

But the guilt shows up. "You've already told him no so many times today." "Poor thing, he's tired." "Maybe I'm being too harsh."

And you give in. Not for him. For you. Because the pain of watching him cry added to the guilt you're already carrying is too much to bear. Giving in is the painkiller. For a few minutes. Then the guilt returns, now with new evidence: "see, you gave in again."

Do you recognize this? It's that moment in the supermarket, when he wants the chocolate and you say no, and he starts crying, and you feel the stares from other people, and the guilt whispers "you've already denied him so much today," and you buy the chocolate. Not because you think it's right. Because the pain of holding the no is greater than the cost of giving in.

It's at night, when she asks to sleep in your bed and you know you need your space, that she needs to learn to fall asleep on her own, but the guilt says "poor thing, during the day you barely saw her," and you open the bed.

It's when he doesn't want to eat and you, instead of respecting the process (he won't starve from skipping dinner), get up from the table, make something else, and something else, and something else, until he eats something, anything, because the guilt of sending him to bed without eating is unbearable.

It's when you decide no more television and, after twenty minutes of crying, you turn the television back on. Not because you've changed your mind. Because the crying, added to the guilt, added to the exhaustion, is an equation with one inevitable result: surrender.

And every time you give in, guilt gains a reason to return. Because giving in against your will breeds resentment. And resentment breeds more guilt. And the cycle doesn't stop.

The most painful part is that, deep down, you know that giving in is not love. You know your child needed the boundary. You know that by giving in you're teaching him something you don't want to teach. But in the moment, with the weight you carry, the boundary feels like a luxury you can't afford.

You compensate instead of educating

When guilt becomes chronic, you enter permanent compensation mode. You buy the toy you shouldn't buy. You give the sweet when he's already had three. You do things for him that he should be doing himself. Not because you think it's right. Because you feel you owe him something.

And what you owe him, in your head, is everything you think he's missing: your time, your patience, your calm, your constant presence. Since you can't give him that, you give him things. And things don't fill the gap. Not for him, not for you.

It's the new toy you bring home on Friday because during the week you came home late every day. It's the "yes" to yet another extracurricular activity because you think he deserves everything you never had. It's the special dinner you cook at eleven at night because the next day is his birthday and the guilt says a good mother bakes the cake at home, she doesn't buy it from the bakery.

Compensation is exhausting. And treacherous. Because it looks like love. It looks like dedication. From the outside, it even looks like you're an exceptional mother. But inside, you know the truth: you're not giving out of love. You're paying a debt you invented.

And the debt is never settled. Because guilt invents new interest every day.

There are mothers who compensate with excessive presence. They spend all their time organizing activities, planning outings, filling every moment of silence with stimulation, because a child who is bored is a

child who is being neglected (in the logic of guilt). And the result is a mother who doesn't have five minutes for herself and a child who hasn't learned to be with herself.

Compensation never resolves. It postpones. And while you postpone, what truly needs attention grows in the dark, underneath.

You don't set boundaries

A mother with chronic guilt is afraid to say no. Because every no feels like a rejection. Every boundary feels like abandonment. Every rule feels like taking instead of giving.

"What if he thinks I don't love him?" "What if she feels rejected?"

"What if this is the moment that gets burned into his memory forever and he tells his therapist about it twenty years from now?"

These questions seem exaggerated, but you recognize them, don't you? They run through your mind in real time, while your child is asking you for something and you're deciding whether to say yes or no. Guilt turns every small decision into an event with lifelong consequences.

And without boundaries, children lose their footing. Because a boundary is not a wall. It's an edge. It's what tells the child: here is safe. Here I protect you. Here I know what I'm doing, even when you don't

like it.

A child without boundaries is not a free child. It's an anxious child. Because if nobody tells her where the edge is, she doesn't know how far she can go. And that uncertainty isn't freedom. It's fear.

You see this every day. You see that when you say "no" with firmness and calm, your child resists, but then settles. And that when you say "no" but give in five minutes later, he becomes more agitated, not less. Because what he needed wasn't the yes. It was your certainty. And when you wavered, he lost his ground.

But the guilty mother can't be that edge. Because being the edge means bearing the child's frustration without giving in. And guilt tells her she doesn't have that right. That she's already failed enough to not be able to demand anything more.

You yell and then collapse

There is a pattern that's rarely spoken aloud, but that almost every mother with chronic guilt recognizes.

You accumulate. You endure. You breathe deeply. You count to ten. You use every tool you've read about in the positive parenting books. They work for a while. Two days. Three. Until they don't. Until the exhaus-

tion is so much, the pressure is so much, the noise is so much, that you explode.

You yell. You say things you didn't want to say. You say "I've had enough," "I can't take it anymore," "leave me alone." Or worse, you say something that wounds. Something you see land in your child's eyes like a stone in water.

And then, silence. The guilt rolls in like a tide. And the collapse begins. You cry. You apologize ten times. You hug tightly. You promise never again. And for a day, two, you're the most patient, sweetest, most available mother in the world. Until the cycle starts again.

And then, the shame. Not just guilt. Shame. Because guilt says "I did something bad." Shame says "I am bad." And when you go from "I yelled" to "I'm a mother who yells," the internal damage is different. Because it's no longer a behavior you can change. It's an identity that traps you.

This pattern is not proof that you're a bad mother. It's proof that you're in a system that drains you without replenishing you. Nobody can give endlessly without receiving. And when the tank is empty, the body screams for you. Literally.

The question was never "why do you yell." The question is "what is driving you to the point of yelling." And that question, guilt never lets you ask. Because it's too busy condemning you for the symptom to let you look at the cause.

You apologize for existing

Have you noticed how many times a day you apologize?

"Sorry, Mommy's tired." "Sorry, I couldn't pick him up." "Sorry, I didn't make dinner in time." "Sorry, sorry, sorry."

"Sorry, today Mommy doesn't have the patience." "Sorry, I can't buy that right now." "Sorry, I'm going to have to work this weekend."

You're not apologizing for what you did, but for what you feel you should have been. You apologize for being human. For having limits. For not being the mother guilt tells you you should be.

You apologize for being sick. For needing a moment alone. For not being in the mood to play. For feeling sad for no apparent reason. You apologize for taking up space in your own life.

And your children hear it. And they learn. They learn that their mother is in debt. That their mother owes something. That love is permanently apologizing. And they carry that.

A daughter who grows up watching her mother apologize for existing learns that existing is an imposition. A son who grows up watching his mother erase herself learns that loving someone means disappearing. And the cycle continues. Not out of cruelty. Out of inheritance.

And notice something: you apologize to your children for things you would never apologize for to anyone else. You apologize for being tired, as if tiredness were an offense. You apologize for having needs, as if your needs were an inconvenience. Have you ever apologized to a coworker for being tired? To a friend for needing a moment alone? Probably not. But to your children, you do. Because guilt has convinced you that they deserve a version of you that needs nothing. And that version is not human.

You compare yourself constantly

Guilt has a powerful ally: comparison. And together, they're devastating.

You look at the mother at school who always seems calm. At the friend who posts photos of family outings on Sundays. At your sister who seems to have a perfect relationship with her children. At the influencer who makes healthy, creative meals every day and still has time to do her makeup.

And you compare. Always losing.

It doesn't occur to you that the calm mother might yell at home. That the friend might only post the good moments. That your sister might also cry in the shower. That the influencer might have a team, a nanny, or a loneliness that doesn't show on screen.

Guilt doesn't let you see other people's reality. It only shows you the edited version. And places it next to your raw version, unfiltered, unedited. And says: "compare."

You never win that comparison. Never. Because guilt is the judge and the game has been rigged from the start.

And the most insidious part is that the comparison doesn't stop with other mothers. You compare yourself to yourself. To the mother you were when the first one was born, full of energy and patience. To the

mother you imagined being before you had children. To the mother you are on Saturday mornings, rested, patient, gentle, who disappears on Wednesday at six in the evening, when you can't do it anymore.

"I can be a good mother when I'm well. So why am I not always well?" That question is guilt's perfect trap. Because it turns your exhaustion into a moral failing. As if being exhausted were a choice. As if being at the limit were a character flaw.

You don't take care of yourself

The last thing guilt does is remove you from the equation.

You don't rest because "the kids need me." You don't go out because "I already spend so little time with them." You don't ask for help because "I'm the mother." You don't go to therapy because "there are more urgent things." You don't stop because stopping is proof that you're not giving enough.

You don't drink enough water. You don't eat sitting down. You don't sleep enough. You don't read a book that isn't about children. You don't listen to music that isn't background noise. You don't have a hobby. You don't have time for yourself, but it's not because of a lack of time. It's because guilt has convinced you that your time doesn't belong to you.

You stop going to the doctor because "it's nothing serious." You stop seeing your friends because "I won't leave the kids." You stop doing the things that made you feel alive before you became a mother because now "it doesn't make sense" to spend time on yourself.

And you empty out. Day after day, month after month. Until what remains of you is a functional shell that does everything it needs to do but doesn't feel anything anymore. And then guilt laughs, because now you have one more reason: "I don't feel anything for my children, I really must be a bad mother."

You're not. You're empty. And nobody gives what they don't have.

(If you recognize yourself in this particular point, if you feel that you don't feel, if you're in a state of emotional exhaustion that goes beyond normal tiredness, I ask you to consider seeking professional support. Not because you're "sick." But because deserving help is not a weakness. It's a right. And, often, it's urgent.)

Do you recognize yourself in any of these? Probably in more than one. And the tendency now is to feel guilty for feeling guilty. "Right, I do all of this, I'm horrible."

Stop.

This isn't about being horrible. It's about being trapped in a cycle that nobody explained to you. And the first step to getting out is seeing. And you, right now, are seeing.

5. Where your guilt comes from

If guilt would leave with effort, it would have left by now.

You've already tried. You've read the articles that say "don't feel guilty." You've repeated the positive affirmations. You've promised yourself that tomorrow would be different. And tomorrow the guilt was there again, intact, as if you'd done nothing.

You've tried to rationalize it. "I know I'm a good mother. I know I do what I can." And your mind agrees. But your body doesn't. Your chest is still tight. Your stomach is still tense. The feeling that you're in debt doesn't go away with logical arguments.

Because it doesn't go away with effort. The guilt you carry was not born with you. It was not born when you became a mother. It's older than that.

The guilt you inherited

In many families, guilt is an inheritance. It passes from mother to daughter the way eye color or a way of laughing does. It's not transmitted with words. It's transmitted with gestures, with silences, with the

way your mother breathed when she felt she had failed.

You didn't learn to feel guilt when your child was born. You learned it long before. You learned it when you watched your mother apologize for things that weren't her fault. When you saw your grandmother sacrifice everything for everyone and never ask for anything for herself. When you heard, even without words: "a good mother doesn't rest, doesn't complain, doesn't fail."

You learned it when your mother got up from the table to serve everyone and ate standing up, in the kitchen, whatever was left. When she said "I don't need anything" with a voice that said exactly the opposite. When she was sick and kept doing everything because "who does it if I don't?"

You didn't decide to feel guilt. You absorbed it. Your body learned, long before your mind, that being a mother means carrying. That being a woman means enduring. That needing is a luxury. That resting is selfishness.

That rule isn't yours. But your body absorbed it. And now it runs on automatic.

And there's another inheritance, more subtle: the inheritance of guilt as proof of love. In many families, the mother who doesn't suffer is suspect. The mother who's happy is selfish. The mother who takes care of herself "forgot about her children." There's a silent equation that says: the more you suffer, the more you love. The more you sacrifice, the better mother you are.

You know, rationally, that this isn't true. But your body knows something else. Your body learned that resting is abandoning. That laughing for no reason is frivolity. That taking care of yourself is stealing from others.

And when you try to step outside that logic, when you try to rest or have pleasure or simply be well, a voice appears that says: "how can you be well when there's so much to do?" And we're back to the same place.

The guilt society feeds

There's another source of guilt that doesn't come from your family. It comes from the outside. It comes from the world.

We live in a society that judges mothers with a silent brutality. If you work, you're "abandoning" your children. If you stay home, you're "wasting" your potential. If you're strict, you're "cold." If you're permissive, you're "negligent." If you ask for help, "you can't handle it." If you don't ask, "you're too proud."

There's no way to win. Because the rules were made so that you lose.

Society expects you to be everything at once: excellent professional, present mother, devoted wife, attractive woman, attentive daughter, available friend. And when you can't be everything (and nobody can, because it's humanly impossible), society shrugs and says: "others manage."

And the guilt listens. And takes note.

The pressure doesn't come only from social media, though social media amplifies everything. It comes from the pediatrician who makes a comment about your child's weight. From the teacher who suggests that "maybe you should spend more time as a family." From the mother-in-law who says "in my day, we did everything and we didn't complain." From the husband who, without malice, asks "what were you doing all day?"

Each of these comments is small. On its own, it would be nothing. But added up, day after day, year after year, they build a narrative: you're not handling it. You're not enough.

And guilt feeds on that narrative as if it were fuel.

And there's more. There's the specific guilt of the mother who is self-employed, who feels that because she has "flexible hours," she should be more present (as if being self-employed didn't often mean working twice as much). There's the guilt of the stay-at-home mother, who feels she should do more because "she doesn't even work." There's the guilt of the separated mother, who carries the pain of having "broken up the family." There's the guilt of the mother who didn't want to breastfeed, or couldn't, or stopped earlier than she "should have." There's the guilt of the mother who didn't feel that instant love when the baby was born and thought there was something wrong with her.

Each of these guilts has different roots. But they all drink from the same river: the idea that there's a right way to be a mother and you haven't found it.

That right way doesn't exist. But the myth persists. And guilt lives on it.

Carrying what doesn't belong to you

There's another origin of guilt that is less obvious and deeper. In the reading of family systems, which I study in my systemic family constellation training, there is a phenomenon that repeats itself: people who carry emotions that aren't theirs.

A mother feels overwhelming guilt about her children and, when she looks more carefully, realizes that the guilt isn't about her children. It's about her own mother. Or about a grandmother who lost a child. Or about a family secret that was never spoken but weighs on everyone.

Sometimes it's a story of abandonment in the previous generation. A great-grandmother who had to leave a child behind. A grandmother who made an impossible choice and never forgave herself. A mother who carried the shame of not being able to give what she wanted. And that guilt, unresolved, unspoken, passes on. It passes like an underground river that you can't see but that wets everything.

You feel guilt. But it may not be your guilt. It may be the guilt of someone who came before you, and you, out of love for the system, carry it without knowing.

This isn't mysticism. It's a pattern observed clinically in work with families. And it's one of the reasons guilt doesn't go away with effort: because you're trying to resolve a pain that isn't yours with tools that don't work for that purpose.

How do you know if you're carrying something that isn't yours? There are signs. The guilt seems disproportionate to what happened. You feel a background sadness that has no logical explanation. There's a sense of debt you can't connect to anything concrete. You feel you "owe" something, but you don't know to whom. Or you do know, and it's to someone who's no longer here.

These may be signs that your guilt has deeper roots than your own story. And that's not a problem. It's information. And information is the first step toward letting go of what you don't need to carry.

You don't need to know your family's entire history to feel this. You don't need to know the details. Sometimes it's enough to stop and ask: "is this guilt mine, or does it belong to someone who came before me?" And the body answers. Not always with words. Sometimes with a sigh. Sometimes with tears that seem to come from a place older than your own memory. And that is the sign that there's something to give back.

Guilt as protection

There is yet another layer. Guilt, as painful as it is, protects you from something worse: helplessness.

As long as you feel guilty, you feel that you could have done differently. That there was a better version possible. That if you try harder, next time it will be different.

The alternative would be accepting that there are things you can't control. That your children will suffer, regardless of what you do. That you are limited. That your love doesn't protect them from everything.

That your son might be hurt on the playground and you can't prevent it. That your daughter might go through things in adolescence that you'll never know about. That they will, inevitably, have pains that your love cannot prevent.

That truth is more frightening than guilt. So your system prefers guilt. Because guilt gives you the illusion of control. "If it's my fault, then I can change it." It's painful, but it's more bearable than "there's nothing I can do."

Guilt says: "if I were a better mother, he wouldn't have this difficulty."
Helplessness says: "he has this difficulty and I can't solve it for him."
The first one hurts. The second one terrifies. So guilt wins.

There are mothers who would rather carry the weight of guilt for years than face, for a moment, the idea that they can't protect their children from everything. And that's not weakness. It's love taken to the extreme. A love that says "I'd rather suffer than accept that you will suffer and I can't stop it."

But that love, when it lacks awareness, imprisons. It imprisons you and it imprisons your children. Because a mother who doesn't accept her helplessness becomes controlling. She tries to predict everything, prevent everything, solve everything. And in doing so, she takes away her children's opportunity to learn to deal with life. With frustrations. With pain. With the fact that life, no matter how much love it holds, includes suffering.

Understanding where your guilt comes from doesn't erase it. But it strips it of absolute power. When you realize that guilt is not proof of failure, that it may be inheritance, that it may be social pressure, that it may be protection, that it may not even be yours, something shifts. Not overnight. But it shifts.

Guilt stops being a truth and becomes a question. And questions can be explored. Absolute truths cannot.

6. The difference between guilt and responsibility

This distinction, on its own, is worth more than everything you've read so far.

Guilt and responsibility seem like the same thing. But they're not. They're opposites.

Guilt sinks you

Guilt looks backward. It finds the mistake. It grabs hold of it. It replays it in your head a thousand times. It turns it into proof of who you are. "I yelled. Therefore, I'm a bad mother." "I wasn't present. Therefore, I'm ruining my children." "I can't handle everything. Therefore, I shouldn't have become a mother."

Guilt doesn't let you learn from the mistake. It chains you to the mistake. You identify with it. And from then on, every decision you make is contaminated: you decide out of fear, out of compensation, out of pity, out of desperation.

Imagine this: you yell at your child at dinner. Guilt grabs that moment and turns it into a film that plays on repeat. You yelling. His face. The silence after. And it replays. And replays. And each time it replays, you feel worse. And instead of thinking about what you can do differently, you stay stuck in the scene, reliving it, modifying it in your head, imagining what it would have been like if you hadn't yelled.

Guilt doesn't improve anything. It replays everything.

Responsibility lifts you

Responsibility also looks at the mistake. But it doesn't stay there. It looks, acknowledges, and asks: "what do I do now?"

Responsibility says: "I yelled. It happened. What can I do differently next time? What was I feeling before I yelled? What did I need in that moment that I wasn't getting?"

Responsibility says: "I yelled because I was exhausted, because I hadn't eaten, because I had an impossible day at work, because nobody helped me, because I accumulated tension for hours. The yell wasn't about him. It was about me. And I need to take care of this."

Responsibility doesn't condemn you. It gives you information. And with information, you can act. Not with desperation. With awareness.

Responsibility allows you to go to your child and say: "Mommy yelled. I shouldn't have yelled. It wasn't your fault. Mommy was tired and reacted badly. I'm sorry." And then, to act so that the conditions that led to the yell change. Not out of guilt. Out of responsibility.

Do you see the difference? With guilt, you spend three days ruminating over the yell. With responsibility, you repair the damage, learn from what happened, and act to change the conditions. Guilt is circular. Responsibility is linear. A wheel. An arrow.

And there's another fundamental difference: guilt is about you. Responsibility is about the other person. Guilt says "I'm horrible for yelling." Responsibility says "he felt scared and I can take care of that." One traps you in your own suffering. The other takes you toward the person who needs you.

The question that changes everything

Next time guilt shows up, try asking yourself this question: "is this guilt or responsibility?"

If the answer sinks you, if it makes you feel small, if it drains you of the energy to act, it's guilt.

If the answer gives you something to do, if it shows you a path, if it gives you back some power, it's responsibility.

And choose responsibility. Not because it's easy. Because it's useful.

Let me give you a concrete example. Your child comes home from school sad. He tells you that nobody played with him. Guilt says: "if I were more present, if I had prepared him better, if I had chosen a different school, this wouldn't have happened." It sinks you. It paralyzes you. It doesn't help you or him.

Responsibility says: "he's sad. What can I do now? I can listen to him. I can be present. I can help him think of ways to deal with this. I can talk to his teacher. I can hold him." It lifts you. It moves you. It helps.

Another example. Your daughter tells you she feels lonely. Guilt says: "it's my fault, I should have been more present, I should have organized more playdates, I should have done everything differently." And you stay there, sunk in the pain, unable to do anything for her.

Responsibility says: "she's feeling lonely. That's real. What can I do? I can listen to her without trying to fix it. I can ask her what she needs. I can be beside her in this moment, without blaming myself for its existence." And suddenly, you're available. Not for the past. For the now.

Guilt pulls you out of the present moment. Always. It drags you to yesterday, to last week, to last year. And while you're there, the moment that truly matters passes by. Your child is right in front of you, needing you now, and you're mentally reviewing every mistake you've made before.

Responsibility brings you back to the now. It doesn't ignore the mistake. But it doesn't live there.

Guilt is a chair where you sit staring at the past. Responsibility is a door. And you can choose to stand up.

But there's something I need to tell you honestly: making this distinction on your own, in the middle of the exhaustion, the overload, and the accumulated guilt, is much easier to read than to live. Reading this is the first step. Living this is a process. And processes need space, time, and often someone to walk beside you.

7. There is a way back

You've made it this far. And if you've made it this far, it's because something in this text touched the right place.

I want you to know that there is a way back. Not a way to become a perfect mother (that doesn't exist and never has). But a way to free yourself from a weight that isn't yours. To tell the difference between the guilt that traps you and the responsibility that lifts you. To look at your children without the distorted lens of inadequacy.

It's not a quick path. It's not an easy path. But it's a real path, walked by real women, who carried exactly what you carry and who, step by step, began to set it down.

Women who thought they'd never be able to say "no" without guilt, and who today say it calmly and without collapsing. Women who lived in compensation mode and who today can be present without paying a debt. Women who yelled and then collapsed, and who today can see what's behind the yell before it arrives.

That path has some points I can show you here, in broad strokes.

Setting down what isn't yours

Part of the guilt you carry was not born with you. When you identify it and return it to where it came from (in the symbolic and systemic sense), the weight decreases. It doesn't vanish overnight, but it loses its urgency. Your chest feels lighter. Your breathing deepens.

Setting it down is not rejecting your story. It's not turning your back on your family. It's saying, internally: "I see this pain. I respect it. But it's not mine to carry. I return it with love to those it belongs to." And curiously, when you do this, you don't feel less. You feel different. Lighter. More yourself.

Returning to your place

Many mothers, because of guilt, leave their place. They become friends instead of mothers. They become servants instead of figures of reference. They become invisible so their children can shine. And when you return to your place (the place of someone who loves AND educates, who gives AND asks, who is present AND protects her boundaries), your children also return to theirs. And everyone breathes easier.

Returning to your place means saying "no" without feeling indebted. It means allowing your child to feel frustrated without feeling that you're hurting him. It means going out for dinner with a friend without spen-

ding the whole evening checking your phone. It means being the mother, not the hostage.

And when you occupy your place with firmness and tenderness, your children feel safer. Not less loved. Safer. Because they know there is someone there with solid ground, with edges, with certainty. And that is exactly what they need.

Receiving before giving

You can't give what you don't have. And you can't have what you don't let yourself receive. Guilt takes away your right to receive: to rest, to ask for help, to take care of yourself. When you reclaim that right, what you give your children changes. Not in quantity. In quality.

Receiving is not a luxury. It's a condition. An empty mother doesn't give. She functions. And there is an enormous difference between giving and functioning. Giving has presence. Functioning runs on autopilot.

Your children notice the difference. They know when you're giving them attention and when you're following a script. They know when the hug is real and when it's mechanical. Not because they're judges. Be-

cause they're sensitive. And sensitive children need present mothers, not exhausted mothers pretending to be present.

Listening to yourself with more truth

There's a simple practice that doesn't replace any therapeutic process, but that can start to open up space: listening to what you feel without judging.

Next time guilt shows up, instead of pushing it away or believing it blindly, try staying with it for a moment. Without reacting. Without condemning yourself. Without trying to fix it. Just feeling. And asking: "what are you trying to tell me?"

Sometimes guilt is telling you that you're tired. Other times it's telling you that you need help. Other times it's telling you there's something to resolve that has nothing to do with your children.

Listening to guilt is not obeying it. It's treating it as a signal, not a sentence.

Allowing yourself to be imperfect

This sounds simple. It isn't.

Allowing yourself to be imperfect is not a motivational phrase to put in a frame on the wall. It's a daily practice. It's looking at the burned dinner and not adding that information to the guilt file. It's leaving the house with your kids in mismatched clothes and not feeling that it says something about you as a mother. It's saying "I can't today" without adding "and that makes me a failure."

It's allowing bad days to exist. Days when everything goes wrong. Days when nobody behaves, you included. And those days don't erase the good ones. They exist alongside them, as a normal part of a life lived for real.

Perfection is a trap. And the way back means letting it go. Not all at once. But a little at a time.

Start with small things. Leave the dishes and go to bed. Order dinner from outside without inventing justifications. Tell your child "Mommy needs five minutes alone today" without adding "sorry." See if the world ends. (It doesn't.) And the next time, it will be a little easier.

These are outlines. They're the map, not the journey. The journey is longer, deeper, and needs more than words on a page. It needs your voice (the inner one, the true one). It needs presence. It needs the courage to look at places that hurt.

But it's possible. And you don't have to do it alone.

(And if what you've read so far makes you feel you need therapeutic support, listen to that signal. This ebook is a starting point, it doesn't replace professional guidance. There are situations where guilt is intertwined with depression, anxiety, trauma, or burnout, and in those cases the help of a therapist is not a luxury. It's a necessity. Seeking that help is not failing. It's taking care of yourself with the same seriousness with which you take care of your children.)

8. The crossing

I wrote this ebook because I believe in one thing: understanding changes things. It doesn't change everything, but it changes enough for you to stop feeling crazy, alone, or defective.

Now you know that guilt is not proof that you've failed. You know where it comes from. You know what it makes you do. You know the difference between guilt and responsibility. And you know there is a way back.

You know you're not the only one who feels this. That you're not "broken." That what you feel is not a sign that you're a bad mother, but rather that you're a mother who loves inside a system that drains her, inside a story that didn't begin with her, inside a culture that judges her for everything she does and everything she doesn't do.

And perhaps, over the course of these pages, something has shifted. Not the guilt itself. That needs more than words. But perhaps the way you look at it. Perhaps, for the first time, you were able to look at your guilt not as proof that you failed, but as a sign that you've been carrying more than belongs to you. And that shift in perspective alone is already enormous.

Because when you see guilt with different eyes, it loses part of its power. It stops being the owner of your story and becomes a character. An important one, yes. But not the only one. And not the one who gets the last word.

Understanding is the first step.

Crossing is another.

That's why I created **FreeMe**.

FreeMe is not a course. It's not content to consume. It's a guided therapeutic crossing that you do from the inside, at your own pace, to set down what was never yours to carry.

There are 7 blockages. Guilt is the first (that's why this ebook exists, it's the gateway). But there are six more: fear, hurt, control, the anger you swallow, sacrifice, and silence. Each with guided exercises, with my voice, with space for your own words to prove the change.

The ebook gave you the map. FreeMe is the journey.

If you feel that it's the right time, I'm there. At freeme.viviannedossantos.com.

And if it's not the right time, that's okay. What you've read here is already yours. The seed is already planted. And when you're ready, the path will be waiting for you.

But I want to ask you one thing before you close this page. I want to ask you to do one thing for yourself today. One small thing. It could be drinking a glass of water in peace. It could be sitting for five minutes without doing anything. It could be looking at yourself in the mirror and saying, even if you don't believe it yet: "I am doing my best. And my best is enough."

You don't have to believe it yet. Just say it. The body hears. And with time, the body begins to remember what it forgot: that you also deserve care. That you are also someone. That before being a mother, you are a person. And that person needs to exist so the mother can give.

With all my tenderness, *Vivianne*

This material is for self-awareness and understanding. It does not replace therapeutic or psychological support. In situations of trauma, depression, severe anxiety, or crisis, please seek help from a mental health

professional. Taking care of yourself is not weakness. It is the most courageous act you can do for the people you love.

© 2025 Vivianne dos Santos · viviannedossantos.com



© 2025 Vivianne dos Santos

viviannedossantos.com

freeme.viviannedossantos.com